

Tonic Wines

Tonic wines are an agreeable way to take strengthening and tonic herbs to increase vitality and improve digestion. Neither strictly medicinal, nor simply appealing to the palate, they are easy to prepare at home. Tonic wines are made by steeping tonic herbs, such as dong quai (*Angelica sinensis*, p. 63), or bitter herbs, such as southernwood (*Artemisia abrotanum*, p. 172), in red or white wine for several weeks.

A simple and effective way to make a tonic wine is in a jar or a ceramic vat with a tap at the base to enable the wine to be drawn off without disturbing the herbs. Wine can be added periodically to keep the herbs covered, although, in time, this will reduce the wine's tonic effectiveness. If exposed to the air, the herbs may get moldy, making the remedy not only ineffective but unsafe to take.

Herbal Wines

Herbal wines are made by fermenting the herb in the same way that wine is produced from grapes. With the correct equipment this is a simple process, but fermentation alters the activity of the herbs and tends to reduce their medicinal value.



1 Place the herb in a large, clean jar or vat. Pour in enough wine to cover the herb completely. Close the jar securely, shake carefully, and leave to stand.



2 Allow the wine to mature over 2–6 weeks, then take a dose from the tap or jar. Regularly top off the mixture with wine.

Standard Quantity

100 g dried or 200 g fresh tonic herbs or 25 g dried bitter herbs and 1 quart (1 liter) of red or white wine

Standard Dosage

Drink ½ cup (70 ml) each day before a meal.

Storage

Use a ceramic vat with a tap at its base, or a sterilized glass jar. Store for 3–4 months, ensuring wine covers the herbs. If the herbs become moldy, discard the remedy.

Syrups

Honey and unrefined sugar are effective preservatives and can be combined with infusions or decoctions to make syrups and cordials. They have the additional benefit of having a soothing action, and therefore make a perfect vehicle for cough mixtures as well as relieving sore throats. With their sweet taste, syrups can disguise the taste of unpalatable herbs and are therefore greatly appreciated by children.

A syrup is made with equal proportions of an herbal infusion or decoction and honey or unrefined sugar. When making an infusion or decoction for a syrup, it needs to be infused or simmered for the maximum time to optimize its medicinal action. Infusions should be infused for 15 minutes and decoctions should be simmered for 30 minutes. Press the soaked herb through the strainer or sieve to remove as much liquid as possible. Small amounts of neat tincture can be added to the cooled syrup to increase its effectiveness.

Syrups Made with Tinctures

Syrups may also be made with tinctures instead of infusions or decoctions. Combine 500 g of honey or unrefined sugar with 1 cup (250 ml) of water. Gently heat until all the sugar or honey has dissolved and the mixture has thickened. Remove from the heat. Once cool, stir 1 part of the tincture, or mixture of tinctures, into 3 parts of the syrup and bottle as directed opposite.



1 Pour the infusion or decoction into a pan. Add the honey or sugar. Gently heat, stirring constantly until all the honey or sugar has dissolved and the mixture has a syrupy consistency. Remove from the heat and cool.

Standard Quantity

2 cups (500 ml) infusion or decoction (see p. 291), infused or heated for the maximum time (see left); 500 g honey or unrefined sugar

Standard Dosage

Take 1–2 tsp (5–10 ml) 3 times a day.

Storage

Store in dark glass bottles with cork tops in a cool place for up to 6 months.



2 Pour the cooled syrup into sterilized glass jars using a funnel and store in a cool, dark place. Seal the jars with cork stoppers, because syrups are prone to ferment and may explode if kept in screw-topped bottles.